Exultavit cor nostrum

Pius IX · 1851-11-21 · English

ENCYCLICAL LETTER
OF OUR HOLY FATHER POPE PIUS IX,
ORDERING PRAYERS AND ANNOUNCING A NEW JUBILEE.

Venerable Brothers—Health and Apostolical Benediction—Qur heart re- joiced in the Lord, Venerable Brothers, and We rendered very great and humble acts of thanksgiving to the most clement and merciful Father, to the God of all consolation, when your numerous testimonies came to inform Us, in the midst'of the incessant and painful sollicitudes with which the calamity of the times overwhelms Us, the very precious and abundant fruits which, by the inspiration of the Divine grace, the flocks committed to your cares had reaped from the favour of the Jubilee which We accorded to them. You informed Us in fact, that on that occasion the Faithful of your dioceses eagerly hastened in great numbers to the churches with humbled spirit and contrite heart, there to hear the word of God, to purify themselves from the defilements of their soul in the Sacrament of Reconciliation, touapproach the Holy Table, and to address, according to Our intention, fervent prayers to Almighty God. From hence it resulted that a great number, by the aid of Divine grace, emerging from the mire of vice, and the shades of error, have re-entered the paths of virtue and truth, and have begun to labour for their salvation. We have been therewith greatly consoled and rejoiced, We who are always so heavily disquieted and preoccupied with the salvation of all those committed to our care by Divine Providence, and We desire nothing with such ardour, We ask nothing else in the vows and prayers which night and day ascend from Our humbled heart unto God, save that all people, all nations, and all families may walk in the ways of the Faith, may know the Lord, and daily love Him more and more, may observe faithfully His holy law, and follow with constancy the way which leads unto life.

But if, on the one hahd, Venerable Brothers, We must feel great joy at learning that the Faithful of your dioceses have renped abundantly the spiritual fruits of the graces of the Jubilee, on the other, it is for Us no slight subject of sorrow to behold what a sad and lamentable spectacle is presented by our

holy religion and civil society in these calamitous times, None among you, Venerable Brothers, is ignorant of the perfidious artifices, the monstrous doctrines, the conspiracies of every kind which the enemies of God and of the human race are setting at work to pervert all minds, to corrupt morals, to cause, if it were possible, religion to disappear from the face of the earth, to shatter all the bonds of civil society, and to destroy it to its very foundations, Hence the deplorable darkness which blinds so many minds, the vehement war which is waged against the whole Catholic religion and this Apostolic chair ; the implacable hatred which persecutes virtue and honesty ; hence the most shame- ful vices which usurp the name of virtue ; the unbridled license of thinking, corrupting, doing everything, and daring everything ; the absolute impatience of all restraint, all power, and all authority; the derision and contempt for the most sacred things, for the holiest laws, for the most excellent institutions; hence, above all, the deplorable corruption of thoughtless youth, the poisonous inundation of bad books, pamphlets, and journals profusely circulated, and propagating everywhere the principles of evil : hence the deadly venom of in. differentism and incredulity, the seditious movements, the sacrilegious conspira- cies, the mockery and outrage of all laws, human and Divine. You are not ignorant, either, Venerable Brethren, what anxiety, what uncertainty, what painful hesitation, what terror, fills and agitates all minds, particularly the minds of good men, who believe with reason that public and private interests, have reason to fear every misfortune when men, wandering miserably from the laws of truth, justice, and religion, in order to give themselves up to the detestable allurements of unbridled passions, meditate every species of crime.

In the midst of so many dangers, who does not see that all our hopes ought to rest solely in God, our salvation ; that to him we ought continually to raise our fervent prayers, in order that His propitious bounty may shed over all nations the riches of His mercy, that He may illuminate every mind with the Heavenly light of His grace, that He may bring back into the path of justice those who are wandering ; that He may vouchsafe to turn towards Him the rebellious wills of His enemies, to infuse into every heart the love and fear of His holy name, and inspire them to think always, and to do always, what is right, what is true, what is pure, what is holy ; and since God is full of sweetness, mildness, and mercy—since He is

bounteous towards those who call upon Him—since He re-

gards the prayer of the humble, and loves especially to manifest His power by clemency and forgiveness, let us approach, Venerable Brethren, the Throne of Grace with confidence, in order to obtain mercy and find assistance in the time of need,

For tie who asks receives, he who secks finds, and to him who knocks it is opened. Letus, in the first place, render immortal thanksgiving to the God of goodness ; in joy let our lips praise His holy name, since in many nations of the Catholic world He deigns to work the wonders of His mercy.

Let us come, then, with one mind animated with the sincerity of the same Faith—with the firmness of the same Hope—with the ardour of the same Charity —let us not cease a single moment to pray and supplicate God humbly and' ear- nestly, that he may rescue His holy Church from every calamity ; that every day it may increase, dilate, and be exalted amongst all people in every region of the earth ; that thus it may purify the world from error, conduct men with tenderness and generosity to the knowledge of truth, and to the way of salvation ; that God being propitiated, may turn away the scourges of his anger, which we hava deserved for our sins—may assuage this stormy ocean and restore tranquillity— may give to all that peace so much desired—may save His people, and, blessing His inheritance, may direct and conduct us to our Heavenly country,

And that God may be made more accessible, and give ear to our prayers, and hear our petitions, let us raise our hearts and hands to His most holy Mother, the immaculate Virgin Mary. We could not find protection more power- ful or more effectual with God. She is to us the most tender of mothers, our firmest reliance, and the very spring of our hopes, since she asks nothing which she does not obtain, and her prayer is never refused. Let us also implore, in the first place, the intercession of the Prince of the Apostles to whom Jesus- Christ himself has given the keys of the kingdom of Heaven—whom He has es- tablished as the foundation-stone of His Church, against which the gates of Hell will never be able to prevail. Let us then pray to Paul, the companion of his Apostleship. Let us pray to the patron of each city and country, and to all the blessed, that our Most Merciful Lord may shed upon us in abundance and munificence the gifts of His bounty.

Moreover, Venerable Brethren, while we ordain here public prayers in our Holy City, we invite you by these letters that you unite yourselves with the people committed to your care with us in a community of petitions. We invoke with all ous geal your fervent devotion and your piciy, in order that in your respective dioceses you may prescribe also public prayers with tie object of im- ploring the Divine mercy. .

Aud in order that the Faithiul may enter with greater ardour and earnest- fess on the prayers which you shall appoint, We have resclved to open anew the celestial treasures of the church under the form of a Jubilee, as will be clear- ly indicated to you by other letters which accompany these.

We entertain this firin hope, Venerable Brothers, that there are angels of peace, whe, helding in their hands censers of gold, will offer on the golden al- tar Ourhurmble prayers, and those of the whole Church, in order that the Lord himself, receiving them favourably, end hearing Our petitions, yours and those of all the Faithful, will dissipatc ali the darkness of error, avert the menacing tempest of so many misfortunes, stretchouta succouring hand to Christian and civil society, and grant that all may have the same Faith in their hearts, the same piety in their works, the same love for religion, virtue, truth, and justice, the settle zeal for peace, the same attachment to thebonds of charity, and that thus throughout the entire world the reign of His only Son our Lord Jesus Christ may beevery (ny more and more augmented, strengthened, and exalted.

Finally, as an anticipatory pledge of every celestial gift, and as a testimony of Our vadent love for yon, receive Our Apostolic Benediction, which, from the hottom of Our heart, we give you with love to you, Venerable Brethren, to ail the Clergy, and toull the Faithful confided to your care.

Given et Rome, at:St. Petec's, the twenty-first day of November, 1851, and of Our Pontificate the sixth.

PIUS IX. Pope

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